

ODYSSEY

become the first Indians to make it to the professional baseball leagues of the United States

| By Siddhartha Vaidyanathan in Bradenton |

Every Pittsburgh baseball fan knows about the 1960 World Series. Pittsburgh Pirates vs New York Yankees, series tied, game tied and then *that* moment—Bill Mazeroski's home-run soaring over the stadium, clearing a 12-ft wall. Fifty years later, two portraits of Mazeroski adorn the wall of Room 223 at the Pittsburgh Pirates' southern base in Bradenton, Florida. It is the home of one of their rookie teams that competes in the Gulf Coast League, the first rung of the United States' pro baseball ladder. Splitting the iconic

photographs is an intricately woven and embroidered wall-hanging. It features Lord Shiva on a throne, surrounded by Parvati, Ganesha and Karthikeya. Below the Mazeroski images are two beds, occupied by boys who neither know his name nor the legend. But every day they pray to Shiva, pray that some day they may be as famous as the Pirate on their wall.

Until January 2008, Rinku Singh and Dinesh Patel, javelin throwers from villages in Uttar Pradesh, had not heard of baseball. Singh's father was a truck driver who raised eight children on Rs 1,500 a month until a bad back forced him into farming in Bhadohi. Patel was raised by a construction worker uncle because his father, a tailor in Gram Khanpur near Varanasi, couldn't support three children.

At inter-district athletic meets, the two country boys shared dreams of going to the Asian Games and the

Olympics. They hoped to join the Indian Army. The only reason they signed up, along with 40,000 others, to take part in a television reality show called *The Million Dollar Arm* was to win some money. The contest was meant to unearth talented pitchers across 30 Indian cities but Singh and Patel know that had a pie-chucking contest offered better prize money, they might have gone there first.

Left-handed Rinku fired one at 89mph (143kmph) to pocket a whopping \$100,000. His friends called him the King of Bhadohi. Right-handed Dinesh earned \$2500 with a 87mph (140 kmph) throw. But neither was prepared for what came next: "It's only then that we realised we were to go to America," Patel says. "*Sab ajeeb sa lag raha tha*, sir. (It seemed weird)."

It's a sweltering July afternoon in Florida—around 40 degrees and muggy. The Pirates have just lost a close game to the Toronto Blue Jays and the Indian boys are mulling over some disappointing pitches. They guide me to their dormitory room,

SINGH (LEFT) AND PATEL IN THEIR LOCKER ROOM OF THE PITTSBURGH SPRING TRAINING BASE, PIRATE CITY, FLORIDA